States and alienate and isolate Iran, Saudi Arabia's main rival both in the religious struggle for the leadership of the Islamic world and in the geostrategic rivalry in the Middle East and the Gulf.

Egypt

Egypt has the largest population among the Arab states. Despite all its efforts, Egypt has not been able to effectively reduce its birthrates, and every ten months the country has a million new mouths to feed. Egypt's sources of income are meager: the Suez Canal, tourism, energy (but in quantities that are not comparable to those of Saudi Arabia and the Gulf States), and foreign workers (Egyptians who work abroad and send money to their families). The majority of the population still live in villages along the banks of the Nile, and the land is worked using methods that are outdated and inefficient. Most of Egypt's territory is desert that cannot be used for agricultural purposes.

Though in 1948 Egypt led the Arab states that invaded Israel with the aim of destroying the nascent Jewish state, it was also the first to embark on a diplomatic process with Israel. In 1979, it signed a comprehensive peace agreement, despite opposition from the PLO, which was recognized by the Arab world as the legitimate representative of the Palestinians.

Like many Arabs—perhaps the majority of them—in the Middle East, the Egyptians, and especially those in the ruling and military circles, view the Palestinians as ungrateful "troublemakers" who do not appreciate the many sacrifices that the Arab nations, chief among them Egypt, have made for them. It can be safely assumed that Egypt would support a solution to the Israeli-Palestinian conflict that it deems as being fair, certainly if it enjoys the support of the two countries on whose assistance Egypt is entirely dependent—the United States and Saudi Arabia.

Moreover, such a solution would help the Egyptian authorities defeat ISIS and their associates in Sinai, as well as to solve the Gaza problem, which, while not their main concern, is a nuisance that they see as needing to be dealt with before it becomes a real threat. A solution to the problem of the Gaza Strip will be possible only within the framework of an Arab and international initiative. This will require the abolition of UNRWA, which